

# Properties of Regular Languages

Closure, Decision Algorithms, and the Pumping Lemma

Computer Science Theory

Slide Set 4

# Table of Contents

- 1 Closure Properties
- 2 Decision Algorithms
- 3 The Pumping Lemma
- 4 Proving Non-Regularity
- 5 Review and Exercises

By the end of this slide set, you should be able to:

- prove closure of the regular languages using automaton constructions and set identities;
- decide membership, emptiness, finiteness, equality, containment, and universality for regular languages;
- state and explain the quantifier structure of the pumping lemma;
- use the pumping lemma to prove selected languages nonregular; and
- recognize invalid pumping-lemma arguments and repair them.

# Part 1: Core Closure Properties

## Self-Study Header: Operating within the Regular World

A class of languages is **closed** under an operation if applying that operation to members of the class always results in a member of the same class.

### Closure Theorem

The family of regular languages is closed under union, intersection, concatenation, complement, and Kleene star.

Formally, if  $L_1$  and  $L_2$  are regular languages, the following are also regular:

- 1 **Union:**  $L_1 \cup L_2$
- 2 **Concatenation:**  $L_1 L_2$
- 3 **Kleene star:**  $L_1^*$
- 4 **Complement:**  $\overline{L_1} = \Sigma^* \setminus L_1$
- 5 **Intersection:**  $L_1 \cap L_2$

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# Proof by Construction: Union Using Grammars

**Theorem:** If  $L_1$  and  $L_2$  are regular, then  $L_1 \cup L_2$  is regular.

## Regular-Grammar Construction

Let  $G_1 = (V_1, \Sigma, S_1, P_1)$  and  $G_2 = (V_2, \Sigma, S_2, P_2)$  be right-linear grammars for  $L_1$  and  $L_2$ . Rename variables so that  $V_1 \cap V_2 = \emptyset$ , and introduce a fresh start variable  $S$ . If unit productions are allowed, define

$$G = (V_1 \cup V_2 \cup \{S\}, \Sigma, S, P_1 \cup P_2 \cup \{S \rightarrow S_1 \mid S_2\}).$$

## Correctness

Every derivation begins by choosing  $S \rightarrow S_1$  or  $S \rightarrow S_2$  and then follows productions from the selected grammar. Therefore  $L(G) = L(G_1) \cup L(G_2) = L_1 \cup L_2$ .

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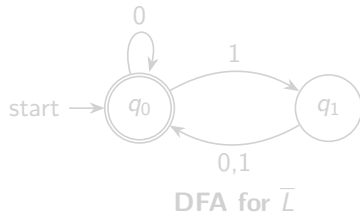
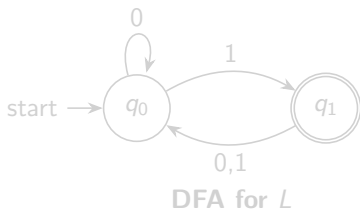
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# Proof by Construction: Complementation

**Theorem:** If  $L$  is regular, then  $\bar{L}$  is regular.

## The Construction

Because  $L$  is regular, a *complete* DFA  $M = (Q, \Sigma, \delta, q_0, F)$  recognizes  $L$ . Construct  $M' = (Q, \Sigma, \delta, q_0, Q \setminus F)$  by swapping the accepting and nonaccepting states.



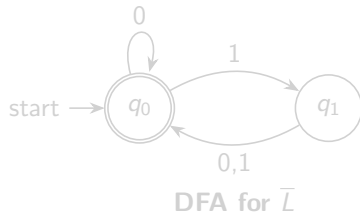
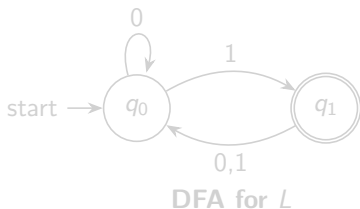
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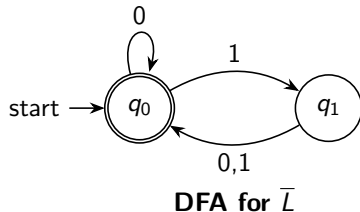
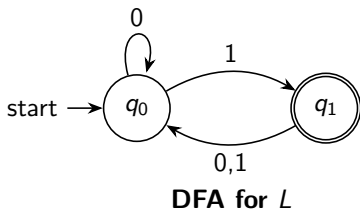
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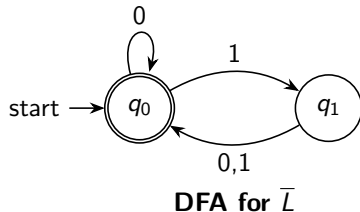
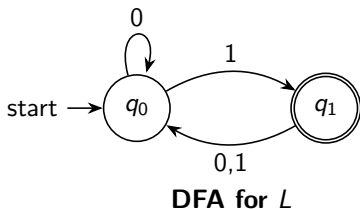
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# Proof by Construction: Intersection

**Theorem:** If  $L_1$  and  $L_2$  are regular, then  $L_1 \cap L_2$  is regular.

## Cartesian Product Construction

Let  $M_1 = (Q_1, \Sigma, \delta_1, s_1, F_1)$  and  $M_2 = (Q_2, \Sigma, \delta_2, s_2, F_2)$ . We build a new DFA  $M_\cap = (Q, \Sigma, \delta, q_0, F)$  that simulates both machines simultaneously:

- $Q = Q_1 \times Q_2$  (the states are pairs).
- $\delta((r_1, r_2), a) = (\delta_1(r_1, a), \delta_2(r_2, a))$ .
- $q_0 = (s_1, s_2)$ .
- $F = F_1 \times F_2$  (accept iff **both** machines accept).

## Alternative Proof via De Morgan's Law

Alternatively,  $L_1 \cap L_2 = \overline{\overline{L_1} \cup \overline{L_2}}$ . Since regular languages are closed under union and complementation, they must be closed under intersection!

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Regular languages are robust and closed under many other operations.

- **Reversal ( $L^R$ ):** Reverse every transition, make the old start state the sole accept state, and add a new start state with  $\epsilon$ -transitions to all old accept states.
- **Difference ( $L_1 \setminus L_2$ ):** Since  $L_1 \setminus L_2 = L_1 \cap \overline{L_2}$ , and regular languages are closed under intersection and complement, they are closed under difference.
- **Homomorphism ( $h(L)$ ):** For each transition labeled  $a$ , replace the edge by a path spelling  $h(a)$ ; use an  $\epsilon$ -transition when  $h(a) = \epsilon$ .
- **Right quotient:**  $L_1/L_2 = \{x : \text{some } y \in L_2 \text{ satisfies } xy \in L_1\}$ . If  $L_1$  and  $L_2$  are regular, then  $L_1/L_2$  is regular.

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# Closure Proof Toolbox

Choose the representation that makes the operation easiest.

## Automaton Constructions

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**Complement:** Complete a DFA and replace  $F$  by  $Q \setminus F$ .

**Concatenation/star:** Connect  $\varepsilon$ -NFAs using the same wrappers as in Thompson's construction.

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**Homomorphism:** Replace each symbol edge by a path spelling its image.

## Set Identities Save Work

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## Part 2: Elementary Questions

### Self-Study Header: Algorithmic Decidability

Given a standard representation of a regular language  $L$  (DFA, NFA, regular expression, or regular grammar), can we algorithmically answer fundamental questions about it?

#### 1. The Membership Question

Given a string  $w$  and a standard representation of  $L$ , is  $w \in L$ ?

**Algorithm:** For a DFA, trace the unique path labeled  $w$  from  $q_0$  and test whether it ends in  $F$ .

**Running time:**  $O(|w|)$  for a supplied DFA. Converting an NFA, RE, or grammar to a DFA is preprocessing and may increase the representation size substantially.

Because the standard representations are effectively convertible, a DFA algorithm establishes decidability for all of them, though not necessarily with the same complexity.

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**Algorithm:** Run BFS or DFS from  $q_0$ . The language is nonempty exactly when some state in  $F$  is reachable.

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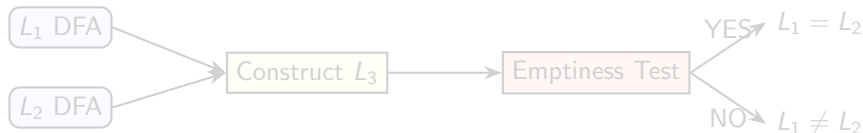
# The Equality Algorithm

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We answer this using the **symmetric difference**:

$$L_3 = (L_1 \cap \overline{L_2}) \cup (\overline{L_1} \cap L_2).$$

$L_3$  contains all strings that are in one language but not the other.  $L_1 = L_2$  if and only if  $L_3 = \emptyset$ .



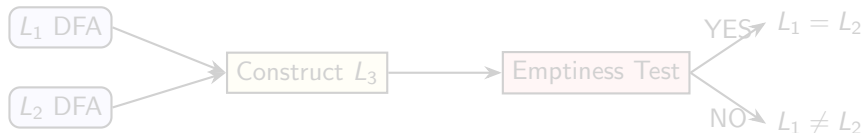
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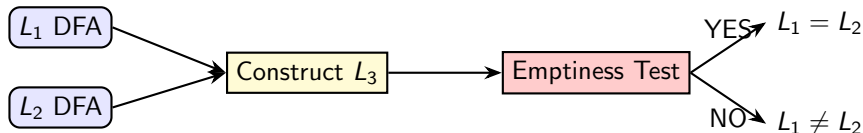
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# More Decidable Questions

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## Reductions to Emptiness

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(universality),

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## Direct Product Test

For equality, build the product DFA and search for a reachable pair in which exactly one component is accepting. Such a path labels a concrete counterexample string distinguishing the two languages.

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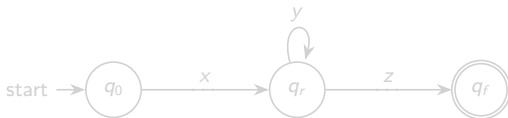
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A DFA has finite memory: its current state records everything relevant about the prefix read so far. What happens when a computation is longer than the number of available states?

### The Pigeonhole Principle

If  $p$  pigeons are placed into fewer than  $p$  holes, some hole has to have more than one pigeon in it.

If a DFA with  $n$  states reads a string of length at least  $n$ , consider the states visited before reading any symbol and after each of the first  $n$  symbols. Among these  $n + 1$  visits, some state repeats. The intervening nonempty input labels a loop within the first  $n$  symbols.



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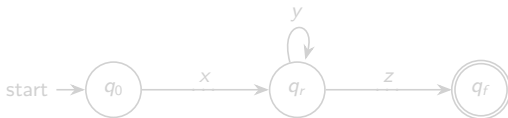
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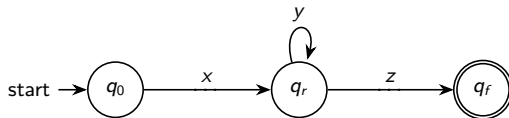
## Self-Study Header: The Limits of Finite Memory

A DFA has finite memory: its current state records everything relevant about the prefix read so far. What happens when a computation is longer than the number of available states?

## The Pigeonhole Principle

If  $p$  pigeons are placed into fewer than  $p$  holes, some hole has to have more than one pigeon in it.

If a DFA with  $n$  states reads a string of length at least  $n$ , consider the states visited before reading any symbol and after each of the first  $n$  symbols. Among these  $n + 1$  visits, some state repeats. The intervening nonempty input labels a loop within the first  $n$  symbols.



# Formal Statement: The Pumping Lemma

## Pumping lemma for regular languages

If  $L$  is regular, then there exists  $p \geq 1$  such that every  $s \in L$  with  $|s| \geq p$  can be written as  $s = xyz$  satisfying:

- 1  $xy^iz \in L$  for every  $i \geq 0$ ,
- 2  $|y| > 0$ , and
- 3  $|xy| \leq p$ .

### Breaking it down:

- Condition 1: The same decomposition works for every pumping value  $i \geq 0$ .
- Condition 2: The loop consumes at least one symbol, so pumping actually changes the string when  $i \neq 1$ .
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# Why the Pumping Lemma Is True

Let a DFA for  $L$  have  $p$  states, and let  $s \in L$  with  $|s| \geq p$ . During the first  $p$  input symbols, record the  $p + 1$  visited states:

$$q_0, q_1, \dots, q_p.$$

Two visits must be equal; choose  $0 \leq r < t \leq p$  with  $q_r = q_t$ . Split  $s$  as follows:

$$\underbrace{s_1 \cdots s_r}_x \underbrace{s_{r+1} \cdots s_t}_y \underbrace{s_{t+1} \cdots s_{|s|}}_z.$$

Then  $|y| = t - r > 0$  and  $|xy| = t \leq p$ . Because reading  $y$  returns the DFA to the same state, the loop may be traversed any number of times; hence  $xy^i z \in L$  for every  $i \geq 0$ .

# Quantifiers and the Lemma's Limitation

The logical order is the heart of a correct nonregularity proof:

$$\exists p \forall s \exists (x, y, z) \forall i \geq 0.$$

To contradict the lemma, reverse the game after assuming regularity:

$$\forall p \exists s \forall (x, y, z) \exists i \geq 0 \text{ such that } xy^iz \notin L,$$

subject to  $s = xyz$ ,  $|s| \geq p$ ,  $|y| > 0$ , and  $|xy| \leq p$ .

## Necessary, Not Sufficient

Every regular language satisfies the pumping lemma, but satisfying the lemma does not by itself prove that a language is regular. Finite languages satisfy it vacuously by choosing  $p$  larger than every string length.

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# The Adversarial Game

The pumping lemma is used **negatively** to prove that a language is not regular. Its quantifiers can be remembered as a four-step game.

## How to play the Pumping Game

- 1 **Opponent:** Gives you the pumping length  $p$  promised by the assumption that the language is regular.
- 2 **You:** Pick a strategic string  $s \in L$  such that  $|s| \geq p$ .
- 3 **Opponent:** Chooses any valid split  $s = xyz$  with  $|y| > 0$  and  $|xy| \leq p$ .
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If this strategy works for every valid split, the initial regularity assumption is false.

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# Example 1: Equal Blocks

**Goal:** Prove  $L = \{a^n b^n : n \geq 0\}$  is not regular.

① Assume  $L$  is regular. The opponent provides pumping length  $p$ .

② **We choose:**  $s = a^p b^p$ . Note that  $s \in L$  and  $|s| = 2p \geq p$ .

③ Opponent divides  $s = xyz$ .

*Crucial insight:* Since  $|xy| \leq p$ , both  $x$  and  $y$  lie in the first block of  $a$ 's. Thus  $y = a^k$  for some  $1 \leq k \leq p$ .

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**Goal:** Prove  $F = \{ww : w \in \{0,1\}^*\}$  is not regular.

- ① Assume  $F$  is regular. Opponent provides pumping length  $p$ .
- ② **We choose:**  $s = 0^p 1 0^p 1 = (0^p 1)(0^p 1)$ .
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## Example 3: Unary Perfect Squares

**Goal:** Prove  $L = \{a^{n^2} : n \geq 0\}$  is not regular.

Pumped string length:  $p^2 + |y|$



Since  $|y| \leq p$ , the pumped length is at most  $p^2 + p$

The next square is  $(p+1)^2 = p^2 + 2p + 1$

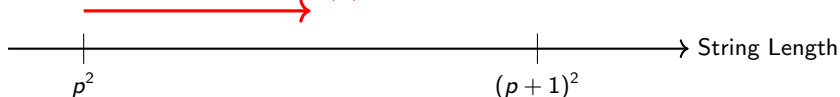
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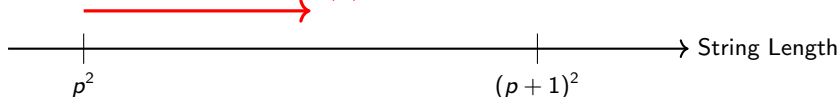
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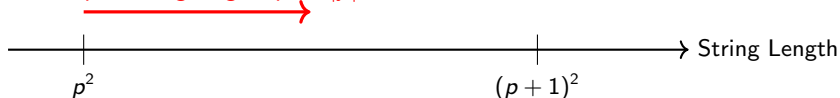
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# Using Closure to Prove Nonregularity

Closure theorems can be used contrapositively.

## Reduction Pattern

To prove a language  $K$  nonregular:

- 1 assume  $K$  is regular;
- 2 apply an operation that preserves regularity; and
- 3 obtain a language already known to be nonregular.

## Example

Let

$$K = \{w \in \{a, b\}^* : |w|_a = |w|_b\}.$$

If  $K$  were regular, then its intersection with the regular language  $a^*b^*$  would be regular. But

$$K \cap a^*b^* = \{a^n b^n : n \geq 0\},$$

contradicting Example 1. Hence  $K$  is not regular.

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Closure theorems can be used contrapositively.

## Reduction Pattern

To prove a language  $K$  nonregular:

- 1 assume  $K$  is regular;
- 2 apply an operation that preserves regularity; and
- 3 obtain a language already known to be nonregular.

## Example

Let

$$K = \{w \in \{a, b\}^* : |w|_a = |w|_b\}.$$

If  $K$  were regular, then its intersection with the regular language  $a^*b^*$  would be regular. But

$$K \cap a^*b^* = \{a^n b^n : n \geq 0\},$$

contradicting Example 1. Hence  $K$  is not regular.

# Checkpoint Exercises

- 1 **Closure Property Trap:** Given that  $L_1$  is regular, and the union  $L_1 \cup L_2$  is regular, does it necessarily follow that  $L_2$  is regular?
- 2 **A Surprising Result:** Let  $D$  contain the strings over  $\{0, 1\}$  having equally many occurrences of 01 and 10 as consecutive substrings. Is  $D$  regular?
- 3 **Choosing  $s$ :** If trying to prove  $L = \{a^n b^n \mid n \geq 0\}$  is not regular, what is wrong with picking  $s = a^2 b^2$  if the opponent's  $p = 5$ ?

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# Teacher's Corner: Common Pitfalls

## Pitfall 1: Picking a specific $p$

Students sometimes begin by fixing  $p = 5$ . This is invalid: the pumping length is an unknown constant. The strategy must work for every  $p \geq 1$ .

## Pitfall 2: Making assumptions about $y$

Even for  $s = a^p b^p$ , you may not assume  $y = a$ . The opponent may choose  $y = a^k$  for any  $1 \leq k \leq p$ . The proof succeeds because pumping every such nonempty block changes only the number of  $a$ 's.

Also verify  $s \in L$ : for example,  $(ab)^p \notin \{a^n b^n : n \geq 0\}$  when  $p > 1$ , so it cannot be used as the witness string for Example 1.

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## Hints and Solutions

- **Exercise 1 (Closure Trap):** False. Let  $L_1 = \Sigma^*$ . Then  $L_1 \cup L_2 = \Sigma^*$  for any  $L_2$ , including a nonregular language.
- **Exercise 2 (01 and 10 substrings):** Yes. Each change  $0 \rightarrow 1$  must eventually be balanced by a change  $1 \rightarrow 0$ , except for a possible net change determined by the endpoints. Thus the counts are equal exactly for  $\varepsilon$  or when the first and last symbols agree; a DFA need only remember the first and current symbols.
- **Exercise 3 (Choosing  $s$ ):** The witness must satisfy  $|s| \geq p$ . If  $p = 5$ , then  $|a^2b^2| = 4$ , so the pumping lemma makes no promise about that string.

### Pro-Tip: Pumping Down

Sometimes pumping up ( $i = 2$ ) does not break the defining property. The lemma also requires  $xy^0z = xz \in L$ , so deleting  $y$  is often the cleaner route to a contradiction.

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# Appendix Road Map

This appendix provides optional material for tutorials, examinations, and advanced self-study:

- ① five additional pumping-lemma proofs in adversarial-game form;
- ② constructive proofs for homomorphism and right quotient;
- ③ solved book-style challenges on regular-language properties; and
- ④ advanced results: Myhill–Nerode, residual languages, Arden's lemma, inverse homomorphisms, and state complexity.

## Suggested use

Select only the examples that match the class level. The main lecture is complete without the appendix.

# Pumping Game A: Binary Palindromes

Prove

$$L = \{w \in \{0,1\}^* : w = w^R\}$$

is not regular.

## Adversarial solution

- ① **Opponent:** Supplies pumping length  $p$ .
- ② **You:** Choose  $s = 0^p 1 0^p$ , a palindrome.
- ③ **Opponent:** Chooses  $s = xyz$  with  $|xy| \leq p$  and  $|y| > 0$ . Hence  $y = 0^k$  for some  $1 \leq k \leq p$ .
- ④ **You:** Pump down with  $i = 0$ :

$$xz = 0^{p-k} 1 0^p.$$

The two sides of the central 1 now have different lengths, so  $xz$  is not a palindrome. This contradicts the pumping lemma.

# Pumping Game B: Unary Prime Lengths

Let

$$L = \{a^q : q \text{ is prime}\}.$$

Assume  $L$  is regular.

## Adversarial solution

- ❶ **Opponent:** Supplies pumping length  $p$ .
- ❷ **You:** Choose a prime  $q \geq p$  and set  $s = a^q$ .
- ❸ **Opponent:** Chooses  $s = xyz$ . Since the alphabet is unary,  $y = a^k$  for some  $1 \leq k \leq p$ .
- ❹ **You:** Choose  $i = q + 1$ . The pumped length is

$$|xy^{q+1}z| = q + qk = q(k + 1).$$

Both factors exceed 1, so the new length is composite. Therefore the pumped string is not in  $L$ , a contradiction.

# Pumping Game C: Powers of Two

Prove

$$L = \{a^{2^n} : n \geq 0\}$$

is not regular.

## Adversarial solution

- ❶ **Opponent:** Supplies pumping length  $p$ .
- ❷ **You:** Choose  $m$  so that  $2^m > p$  and let  $s = a^{2^m}$ .
- ❸ **Opponent:** Chooses  $s = xyz$ , where  $y = a^k$  and  $1 \leq k \leq p$ .
- ❹ **You:** Pump up once, choosing  $i = 2$ . The new length is  $2^m + k$ .

Because

$$2^m < 2^m + k < 2^m + 2^m = 2^{m+1},$$

the pumped length lies strictly between consecutive powers of two.

# Pumping Game D: More Zeros Than Ones

Let

$$L = \{0^n 1^m : n > m \geq 0\}.$$

Assume  $L$  is regular.

## Adversarial solution

- ❶ **Opponent:** Supplies pumping length  $p$ .
- ❷ **You:** Choose  $s = 0^p 1^{p-1} \in L$ .
- ❸ **Opponent:** Chooses  $s = xyz$  with  $|xy| \leq p$ ; therefore  $y = 0^k$  for some  $1 \leq k \leq p$ .
- ❹ **You:** Pump down:

$$xz = 0^{p-k} 1^{p-1}.$$

Since  $p - k \leq p - 1$ , the number of zeros is no longer strictly greater than the number of ones. Thus  $xz \notin L$ .

# Pumping Game E: A Divisibility Constraint

Prove that

$$L = \{a^n b^m : n, m \geq 1 \text{ and } n \mid m\}$$

is not regular.

## Adversarial solution

- ❶ **Opponent:** Supplies pumping length  $p$ .
- ❷ **You:** Choose  $s = a^p b^p \in L$  because  $p \mid p$ .
- ❸ **Opponent:** Chooses  $s = xyz$ . The prefix restriction forces  $y = a^k$  for some  $1 \leq k \leq p$ .
- ❹ **You:** Pump with  $i = 2$ , obtaining

$$xy^2z = a^{p+k}b^p.$$

A positive integer  $p + k > p$  cannot divide the smaller positive integer  $p$ . Hence the pumped string is not in  $L$ .

# Homomorphisms: Definition and Closure Theorem

A homomorphism  $h : \Sigma^* \rightarrow \Gamma^*$  is determined by its values on symbols and extended by

$$h(\varepsilon) = \varepsilon, \quad h(a_1 \cdots a_n) = h(a_1) \cdots h(a_n).$$

## Theorem

If  $L$  is regular, then its homomorphic image  $h(L) = \{h(w) : w \in L\}$  is regular.

## Automaton construction

Let an automaton  $M$  recognize  $L$ . For every transition  $q \xrightarrow{a} r$ :

- replace it by a path spelling  $h(a)$ , using fresh intermediate states when  $|h(a)| > 1$ ;
- use an  $\varepsilon$ -transition when  $h(a) = \varepsilon$ .

Keep the original start and accepting states. The result is an  $\varepsilon$ -NFA.

A path labeled  $w$  in  $M$  becomes a path labeled  $h(w)$  in the new automaton, proving that its language is exactly  $h(L)$ .

# Worked Homomorphism Examples

Let  $L = (01)^*$ .

## Non-erasing homomorphism

If  $h(0) = ab$  and  $h(1) = c$ , then

$$h(L) = \{(abc)^n : n \geq 0\} = (abc)^*.$$

Every transition on 0 is replaced by a two-edge path labeled  $a, b$ , and every transition on 1 becomes a  $c$ -edge.

## Erasing homomorphism

If  $g(0) = ab$  and  $g(1) = \varepsilon$ , then

$$g(L) = (ab)^*.$$

The 1-transition becomes an  $\varepsilon$ -move.

## Common distinction

Homomorphic images may merge distinct source words or erase symbols. Closure states that the resulting language remains regular; it does not claim that  $h$  is one-to-one.

# Right Quotient: Constructive Closure Proof

The right quotient of  $L_1$  by  $L_2$  is

$$L_1/L_2 = \{x : \text{there exists } y \in L_2 \text{ with } xy \in L_1\}.$$

## Theorem

If  $L_1$  and  $L_2$  are regular, then  $L_1/L_2$  is regular.

Let  $M_1 = (Q, \Sigma, \delta, q_0, F)$  recognize  $L_1$ . Define

$$F' = \{q \in Q : \exists y \in L_2, \delta^*(q, y) \in F\}.$$

Use the DFA

$$M' = (Q, \Sigma, \delta, q_0, F').$$

After reading  $x$ ,  $M'$  accepts precisely when some suffix  $y \in L_2$  can take the current state to an old accepting state. Therefore

$$x \in L(M') \iff \exists y \in L_2 : xy \in L_1.$$

The set  $F'$  is computable by product-graph reachability using DFAs for  $L_1$  and  $L_2$ .

# Worked Right-Quotient Examples

## Removing one required suffix

Let  $L_1 = (ab)^*$  and  $L_2 = \{b\}$ . Then

$$L_1/L_2 = \{x : xb \in (ab)^*\} = (ab)^*a.$$

For example,  $aba \in L_1/L_2$  because  $abab \in (ab)^*$ .

## A family of possible suffixes

Over  $\Sigma = \{0, 1\}$ , let  $L_1 = \Sigma^*01$  and  $L_2 = 1^*$ . Then

$$L_1/L_2 = \Sigma^*0 \cup \Sigma^*01.$$

The empty suffix keeps every word already ending in 01; a nonempty suffix from  $1^*$  can complete any word ending in 0.

## Advanced remark

For a fixed regular  $L_1$ ,  $L_1/L_2$  is regular even for arbitrary  $L_2$ , because only a subset of the finitely many states becomes final. Regularity of  $L_2$  makes that subset effectively computable.

# Challenge 1: Prefixes, Suffixes, and Factors

For a language  $L$ , define

$$\text{Pref}(L) = \{x : \exists y, xy \in L\},$$

$$\text{Suff}(L) = \{y : \exists x, xy \in L\},$$

$$\text{Fact}(L) = \{z : \exists x, y, xzy \in L\}.$$

## Claim

If  $L$  is regular, all three languages are regular.

**Solution.** Let  $M$  be a DFA for  $L$ .

- For prefixes, make accepting every state that can reach an old accepting state.
- For suffixes, use an NFA whose possible start states are all states reachable from the original start.
- For factors, combine both changes: start at any reachable state and accept at any state that can reach an old final state.

Each construction has finitely many states, proving regularity.

## Challenge 2: Infinite Regular Subsets

### Problem

Prove that every infinite regular language contains an infinite regular sublanguage.

**Solution.** Let  $p$  be a pumping length for an infinite regular language  $L$ . Choose  $s \in L$  with  $|s| \geq p$ , and take the decomposition  $s = xyz$  guaranteed by the pumping lemma. Then

$$R = \{xy^iz : i \geq 0\}$$

is a subset of  $L$ . Since  $|y| > 0$ , these strings have distinct lengths, so  $R$  is infinite. Moreover,

$$R = \{x\}\{y\}^*\{z\},$$

which is regular by closure under concatenation and star.

### Lesson

An infinite regular language always contains an explicitly describable ultimately periodic family.

## Challenge 3: A Short Witness of Infinitude

### Problem

Let a DFA have  $n$  states. Prove that its language is infinite iff it accepts some word  $w$  satisfying

$$n \leq |w| < 2n.$$

**Forward direction.** Choose a shortest accepted word of length at least  $n$ . If its length were at least  $2n$ , a repeated state among the first  $n + 1$  visits would identify a loop of length at most  $n$ . Removing that loop would leave an accepted word still of length at least  $n$ , contradicting minimality.

**Reverse direction.** Any accepted word of length at least  $n$  repeats a state along its path. Pumping the resulting nonempty loop yields infinitely many accepted words.

### Algorithmic consequence

Finiteness can be tested by searching useful cycles, or equivalently by testing acceptance at lengths  $n, \dots, 2n - 1$ .

# Challenge 4: How Long Is a Counterexample?

## Problem

DFA  $M_1$  has  $m$  states and DFA  $M_2$  has  $n$  states. If their languages differ, show that some distinguishing string has length less than  $mn$ .

**Solution.** Build the product DFA for the symmetric difference. It has at most  $mn$  states and accepts exactly the strings on which the two machines disagree. If the languages differ, an accepting product state is reachable.

Choose a shortest path to such a state. It cannot repeat a product state; otherwise deleting the intervening cycle would give a shorter accepting path. A simple path through at most  $mn$  states has at most  $mn - 1$  edges. Therefore a distinguishing string exists with

$$|w| \leq mn - 1.$$

## Practical use

Breadth-first search in the product not only decides equivalence but returns a shortest counterexample.

## Challenge 5: Counting 01 and 10

Let  $N_{01}(w)$  and  $N_{10}(w)$  count overlapping adjacent occurrences. Determine whether

$$D = \{w : N_{01}(w) = N_{10}(w)\}$$

is regular.

### Key invariant

For every nonempty binary string,

$$N_{01}(w) - N_{10}(w) = \begin{cases} 1, & w \text{ starts with 0 and ends with 1,} \\ -1, & w \text{ starts with 1 and ends with 0,} \\ 0, & w \text{ has equal first and last symbols.} \end{cases}$$

Each change from 0 to 1 is canceled by a later change back, except for the net change between the endpoints. Hence

$$D = \{\varepsilon\} \cup \{0, 1\} \cup 0\Sigma^*0 \cup 1\Sigma^*1,$$

which is regular. A DFA need only remember the first and current symbols.

# About the Book-Style Challenges

The preceding problems are newly phrased solutions based on recurring exercise themes in standard theory-of-computation texts:

- closure constructions and decision algorithms;
- pumping consequences for infinite regular languages;
- product automata and shortest distinguishing strings; and
- finding a finite invariant for a seemingly unbounded counting property.

## Study method

Before reading a solution, identify the most useful representation: DFA graph, product automaton, regular expression, closure identity, or pumping loop. The representation usually reveals the proof.

# Myhill–Nerode: The Exact Regularity Test

For a language  $L \subseteq \Sigma^*$ , define

$$x \equiv_L y \iff \text{for every } z \in \Sigma^*, xz \in L \iff yz \in L.$$

Thus  $x$  and  $y$  are equivalent when no future suffix can distinguish them.

## Myhill–Nerode Theorem

$L$  is regular if and only if  $\equiv_L$  has finitely many equivalence classes. Moreover, the number of classes equals the number of states in the minimal DFA for  $L$ .

## Interpretation

A DFA state represents all prefixes having the same possible futures. Minimization merges exactly the states whose prefixes cannot be distinguished by any continuation.

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# Myhill–Nerode Nonregularity Proof

Prove again that

$$L = \{a^n b^n : n \geq 0\}$$

is not regular. Consider the infinite collection of prefixes  $\varepsilon, a, a^2, a^3, \dots$ . If  $i < j$ , choose the distinguishing suffix  $z = b^i$ . Then

$$a^i z = a^i b^i \in L, \quad a^j z = a^j b^i \notin L.$$

Therefore  $a^i \not\equiv_L a^j$  whenever  $i \neq j$ .

The relation  $\equiv_L$  has infinitely many classes, so the Myhill–Nerode theorem implies that  $L$  is not regular.

## Compared with pumping

The pumping lemma gives a necessary property of regular languages. Myhill–Nerode gives an exact characterization and also explains the state count of the minimal DFA.

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# Residual Languages and the Minimal DFA

The **left quotient** or **residual** of  $L$  by a word  $x$  is

$$x^{-1}L = \{z \in \Sigma^* : xz \in L\}.$$

It records all suffixes that can complete the prefix  $x$  into a word of  $L$ .

## Structural facts

- $x \equiv_L y$  exactly when  $x^{-1}L = y^{-1}L$ .
- The distinct residuals of a regular language can serve as the states of its minimal DFA.
- The start state is  $\varepsilon^{-1}L = L$ ; a residual is accepting exactly when it contains  $\varepsilon$ .
- Reading  $a$  moves  $x^{-1}L$  to  $(xa)^{-1}L$ .

Hence the minimal DFA is unique up to renaming states: its states are the language's intrinsically different future behaviors.

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# Arden's Lemma: Solving Language Equations

## Arden's Lemma

If  $X, A, B \subseteq \Sigma^*$  satisfy

$$X = AX \cup B$$

and  $\varepsilon \notin A$ , then the unique solution is

$$X = A^*B.$$

Indeed, repeatedly substituting for  $X$  gives  $X = B \cup AB \cup A^2B \cup \dots = A^*B$ . The condition  $\varepsilon \notin A$  guarantees uniqueness.

## Example

The equation  $X = aX \cup b$  has solution

$$X = a^*b.$$

Systems of such equations provide a systematic route from a finite automaton to a regular expression.

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# Inverse Homomorphisms Preserve Regularity

For a homomorphism  $h : \Sigma^* \rightarrow \Gamma^*$  and  $L \subseteq \Gamma^*$ , define

$$h^{-1}(L) = \{w \in \Sigma^* : h(w) \in L\}.$$

Let  $M = (Q, \Gamma, \delta, q_0, F)$  be a DFA for  $L$ . Construct a DFA over  $\Sigma$  with the same states, start state, and final states, but define

$$\delta'(q, a) = \delta^*(q, h(a)).$$

By induction on  $w$ ,  $\delta'^*(q_0, w) = \delta^*(q_0, h(w))$ . Thus the new DFA accepts  $w$  exactly when  $h(w) \in L$ .

## Example

If  $h(0) = ab$ ,  $h(1) = a$ , and  $L = (ab)^*$ , then  $h^{-1}(L) = 0^*$ : every 0 contributes one  $ab$ , while any 1 leaves an unmatched  $a$ .

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For a homomorphism  $h : \Sigma^* \rightarrow \Gamma^*$  and  $L \subseteq \Gamma^*$ , define

$$h^{-1}(L) = \{w \in \Sigma^* : h(w) \in L\}.$$

Let  $M = (Q, \Gamma, \delta, q_0, F)$  be a DFA for  $L$ . Construct a DFA over  $\Sigma$  with the same states, start state, and final states, but define

$$\delta'(q, a) = \delta^*(q, h(a)).$$

By induction on  $w$ ,  $\delta'^*(q_0, w) = \delta^*(q_0, h(w))$ . Thus the new DFA accepts  $w$  exactly when  $h(w) \in L$ .

## Example

If  $h(0) = ab$ ,  $h(1) = a$ , and  $L = (ab)^*$ , then  $h^{-1}(L) = 0^*$ : every 0 contributes one  $ab$ , while any 1 leaves an unmatched  $a$ .

# State Complexity: Construction Size Matters

Closure proves that a result is regular; **state complexity** asks how large a recognizing DFA may need to be.

| Operation or conversion                         | General upper bound      |
|-------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| complement of an $n$ -state complete DFA        | $n$ states               |
| union/intersection of $m$ - and $n$ -state DFAs | $mn$ states              |
| determinization of an $n$ -state NFA            | $2^n$ subset states      |
| reversal of an $n$ -state DFA                   | at most $2^n$ DFA states |

These are worst-case bounds: unreachable or equivalent constructed states may be removed, although suitable language families attain exponential or product-size growth.

## Practical lesson

A mathematically simple closure construction can cause a substantial representation blow-up. Build reachable states on demand and minimize only when the application benefits from it.

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# Further Regular-Language Observations

- Every finite language is regular, and every infinite regular language contains an infinite regular sublanguage.
- A unary regular language has an *ultimately periodic* set of accepted lengths: after some point, membership repeats with a fixed period.
- Two DFA states are inequivalent exactly when some suffix is accepted from one state and rejected from the other; partition refinement finds these equivalence classes efficiently.
- The pumping length may be chosen as the number of states of a DFA, but it need not be the smallest possible pumping length for the language.
- Regular expressions, right-linear grammars, DFAs, and NFAs have the same expressive power, but conversions between them can change the representation size dramatically.

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# Appendix References and Further Practice



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The appendix problems are original formulations of standard exercise themes; consult these texts for further variations on closure, minimization, language equations, and nonregularity proofs.